

4 must-have behavioural interview stories for Sr/Staff+ eng. roles



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Most candidates only
prepare success stories.
But if you're going for a Staff
or Principal Engineer role,
the bar is different

You're expected to show
influence, judgment,
resilience, and org-level
impact, not just execution





Here are the
4 types
of stories you
MUST have
ready:



#1

***When you
influenced
someone who
initially
disagreed with
your solution***



What it's assessing:

- Your ability to persuade peers or leadership without authority
- Technical conviction + interpersonal finesse
- Cross-functional collaboration and stakeholder management

What to highlight:

- How you listened to their concerns first
- Data, prototypes, or experiments you used to convince them
- The business or technical impact of your idea being adopted

Red flags to avoid:

- Making the other party look incompetent
- Bragging or sounding combative (“I proved them wrong”)
- Ignoring empathy or relationship-building



#2

***When you
disagreed but
went with the
team's decision***



What it's assessing:

- Your maturity and ego-free collaboration
- How you balance conviction with alignment
- Ownership even when the outcome isn't yours

What to highlight:

- How you made your case clearly and respectfully
- Why the team chose the other direction
- How you committed fully and helped make it successful anyway

Red flags to avoid:

- Blaming others if the solution failed
- Sounding bitter or passive-aggressive
- Saying “I told you so” in any form



#3

***When you failed
- missed a
deadline,
shipped a
buggy feature,
or your solution
flopped***



What it's assessing:

- Your self-awareness and growth mindset
- How you handle setbacks and accountability
- Emotional resilience and recovery

What to highlight:

- What went wrong and why (be specific)
- What you learned and what you'd do differently
- How you regained trust or corrected course

Red flags to avoid:

- Blaming external factors or "bad PMs"
- Being vague ("communication issues")
- Minimizing the impact or not owning the failure



#4

***When you drove
a strategy that
changed the
course of your
org or team***



What it's assessing:

- Strategic thinking and long-term vision
- Org-level influence and system-wide understanding
- Your ability to create leverage for others

What to highlight:

- The problem or inefficiency you spotted
- How you aligned stakeholders and executed the change
- Tangible results (speed, quality, team morale, cost)

Red flags to avoid:

- Only talking about individual contribution
- Lack of metrics or evidence of impact
- Overengineering a solution without org buy-in





At the Sr/Staff+ level, your behavioral stories matter as much as your system design rounds.

They reveal how you lead without authority, drive change, and think at scale.



That's a wrap

Prepare for these 4 types of stories before your next Sr/Staff+ behavioural interview.

1. When you influenced someone who initially disagreed with your solution
2. When you disagreed but went with the team's decision
3. When you failed - missed a deadline, shipped a buggy feature, or your solution flopped
4. When you drove a strategy that changed the course of your org or team





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